Summary

Sustainable Glam

Subject	Year	Start date	Duration
Design	MYP1	Week 1, January	19 weeks

Description

In the unit *Sustainable Glam*, students explore how cosmetic products are shaped by market trends, user needs, and sustainability within the global beauty industry. Situated in the global context of Globalization and Sustainability, students take on the role of eco-conscious cosmetic designers tasked with creating a natural, functional lip balm for a specific target audience. Through research, experimentation, and iterative design, students investigate skin-safe ingredients, ethical sourcing, sustainable packaging, and branding strategies. They apply the full International Baccalaureate MYP Design cycle to develop, create, test, and evaluate a prototype, culminating in a promotional pitch that communicates both product value and environmental responsibility.

Key and Related Concepts

Key Concepts

Key Concepts	Definition
Development	**Development** is the act or process of growth, progress or evolution, sometimes through iterative improvements.

Related Concept(s)

Markets and trends, Resources

Inquiry

Conceptual Understanding

Purposeful cosmetic design, shaped by market trends and responsible use of resources, enables sustainable and ethical product solutions that meet user needs within a globalized context.

Global Context

Global Context	Explorations to develop
Globalization and	Human impact on the environment, Markets, Consumption

Global Context	Explorations to develop
sustainability	

Statement of Inquiry

Development of design solutions is shaped by evolving markets and trends, and responsible use of resources enables sustainable responses in an interconnected global environment.

Inquiry Questions

Type	Inquiry Questions	Line of Inquiry
Factual	What are the key ingredients in a natural lip balm?	The role of natural ingredients in determining the safety, performance, texture, and sustainability of lip balm products.
Factual	How do different ingredients affect texture and shelf life?	The relationship between ingredient properties, formulation ratios, and their impact on the texture, stability, and shelf life of cosmetic products.
Conceptual	How can cosmetic design reflect sustainability and user needs?	Cosmetic design integrates sustainability and user needs by balancing ethical material choices, functionality, and aesthetic appeal to create responsible and meaningful products.
Conceptual	What makes a cosmetic product functional and appealing?	Understanding how functionality, aesthetics, and sustainability interact in cosmetic design enables the creation of products that are both appealing to users and responsible in a global market.
Debatable	Should cosmetic products prioritize sustainability over performance?	Ethical cosmetic design requires balancing sustainability and performance, as design choices influenced by market expectations and resource use shape both product effectiveness and environmental impact in a globalized world.
Debatable	Is it ethical to use mica and other mined ingredients in cosmetics if their extraction involves exploitative labor practices?	Ethical cosmetic design requires designers to critically evaluate the social and environmental impact of mined ingredients, as global supply chains and resource choices influence sustainability, human rights, and responsible consumption.

Curriculum

Aims

Develop knowledge, understanding and skills from different disciplines to design and create solutions to problems using the design cycle

Develop an appreciation of the impact of design innovations for life, global society and environments

MYP subject group objective(s)

A: Inquiring and analysing

i. explain and justify the need for a solution to a problem

ii. state and prioritize the main points of research needed to develop a solution to the problem

iii. describe the main features of an existing product that inspires a solution to the problem

iv. present the main findings of relevant research

B: Developing ideas

i. develop a list of success criteria for the solution

ii. present feasible design ideas, which can be correctly interpreted by others

iii. present the chosen design

iv. create a planning drawing/diagram, which outlines the main details for making the chosen solution

C: Creating the solution

i. outline a plan, which considers the use of resources and time, sufficient for peers to be able to follow to create the solution

ii. demonstrate excellent technical skills when making the solution

iii. follow the plan to create the solution, which functions as intended

iv. list the changes made to the chosen design and plan when making the solution

D: Evaluating

i. outline simple, relevant testing methods, which generate data, to measure the success of the solution

ii. outline the success of the solution against the design specification

iii. outline how the solution could be improved

iv. outline the impact of the solution on the client/target audience

Content (topics, knowledge, skills)

Ingredients used in lip balm (waxes, oils, scents, pigments)

Understanding of skin-safe and sustainable materials

Basics of product formulation and preservation

Branding and marketing fundamentals

Skills

Measuring and mixing ingredients accurately

Designing labels and packaging

Applying the design cycle

Reflecting on the effectiveness of the final product

ATL Skills

ATL skills

Description
ATL Task 1: Green Screen Sustainability Advertisement
(ATL: Communication & Media Literacy)

Purpose
Students communicate design intent and sustainability values while analyzing how media techniques influence audience perception.

Process
Students create a 30–45 second green screen advertisement for their lip balm using iMovie. They must intentionally choose background visuals (nature, laboratories, supply chains), tone, language, and slogans to appeal to eco-conscious consumers. A planning storyboard is required, justifying media choices and claims made about sustainability.

Explicit ATL Skill Development

- Communication: Organizing ideas clearly for a target audience
- Media Literacy: Understanding how visual and audio elements shape meaning and credibility

Assessment Evidence
Advertisement video, storyboard, and a short reflection on how media choices affected audience engagement.

ATL Task 2 : Ethical Media Deconstruction & Reframing Task
(ATL: Media Literacy & Communication)

Purpose
Students learn to critically interpret cosmetic advertising and responsibly communicate ethical information.

Process
Students analyze 2–3 real cosmetic advertisements that claim to be “natural,” “ethical,” or “sustainable.” Using a guided analysis sheet, they identify persuasive techniques, missing information (e.g., ingredient sourcing like mica), and potential greenwashing. Students then rewrite one claim or redesign a visual to make it more ethically transparent and honest.

Explicit ATL Skill Development

- Media Literacy: Evaluating bias, omissions, and representation in media
- Communication: Reframing messages accurately for informed audiences

Assessment Evidence

Completed analysis sheet, revised claim/visual, and a brief justification explaining ethical improvements.

Communication

- I. Communication skills

  Exchanging thoughts, messages and information effectively through interaction

  Collaborate with peers and experts using a variety of digital environments and media

Research

- VII. Media literacy skills

  Interacting with media to use and create ideas and information

  Understand the impact of media representations and modes of presentation

Developing IB Learners

IB Learner Profile

Caring

Reflective

Integration

International Mindedness

This unit enables students to engage meaningfully with issues of global importance by situating cosmetic design within the interconnected global systems of resource extraction, production, consumption, and ethics. Through the study of natural ingredients, sustainability, and ethical sourcing particularly the use of mined materials such as mica, students examine how everyday consumer products are linked to global supply chains, environmental impact, and labor practices in different parts of the world.

Students analyse how cosmetic trends and beauty standards vary across cultures, climates, and socioeconomic contexts, and how these differences influence user needs, product formulation, and marketing strategies. By evaluating perspectives of consumers, manufacturers, workers, and advocacy groups from diverse regions, students develop an understanding of how design decisions can either reinforce or challenge inequities. The unit encourages students to move beyond a local viewpoint, fostering international-mindedness and ethical responsibility by positioning design as a powerful tool for informed, culturally aware, and sustainable decision-making.

Academic Integrity

The principles of academic integrity will be reinforced throughout this unit by explicitly embedding ethical research, responsible collaboration, and honest communication practices at each stage of the design cycle. Students will be taught how to correctly research and reference sources when investigating cosmetic ingredients, sustainability claims, and ethical issues such as mica mining, ensuring that ideas, data, and media content are appropriately acknowledged.

During product formulation, testing, and media creation, students will be required to document their process using original photographs, videos, and reflections, reinforcing authenticity of work. Collaborative tasks will include clearly defined roles and peer agreements to promote equitable contribution and responsible teamwork. When creating advertisements and promotional materials, students will critically examine greenwashing and misleading claims, emphasizing truthful representation and ethical communication. Reflection and evaluation tasks will require students to acknowledge limitations, feedback, and sources of influence, reinforcing academic honesty, transparency, and respect for intellectual property throughout the unit.

Connections

Language Development

This unit supports the language development of students by providing sustained opportunities to use subject-specific and academic language in meaningful, authentic contexts. Students engage with technical vocabulary related to cosmetic science, sustainability, and design such as ingredient functions, ethical sourcing, branding, and market trends through research, discussions, and written design documentation. Explicit scaffolding is provided through glossaries, success criteria, and model exemplars to support accurate and confident language use.

Oral communication skills are strengthened through collaborative planning, peer feedback, and the creation of a marketing pitch and green screen advertisement, requiring students to adapt tone, vocabulary, and structure for a specific audience. Students also develop critical reading and media literacy skills by analysing advertisements and sustainability claims. Reflection and evaluation tasks further support written language development, encouraging students to articulate ideas clearly, justify decisions, and use appropriate academic conventions.

Information Communication Technology

Information literacy and the use of ICT are intentionally embedded throughout this unit to support informed, ethical, and effective design practices. Students develop information literacy by learning how to locate, evaluate, and synthesize information from credible digital sources when researching cosmetic ingredients, sustainability claims, and ethical issues such as mica mining. Emphasis is placed on distinguishing scientific evidence from marketing claims, identifying bias and greenwashing, and accurately referencing sources.

ICT skills are developed through the use of digital tools for research, collaboration, documentation, and media creation. Students use design software and video-editing platforms such as iMovie to create green screen advertisements, digital storyboards, and promotional materials. Collaborative digital environments support peer feedback and project management, while reflective use of ICT enables students to document their design process, test results, and evaluations, reinforcing responsible, purposeful, and ethical use of technology.

Service as Action

This unit provides authentic opportunities for students to translate learning into principled action by using design as a means of advocacy, awareness, and community engagement. Students apply their understanding of sustainability, ethical sourcing, and responsible consumption beyond the classroom through the following initiatives:

Students create awareness about natural products and sustainable cosmetic practices by developing an ethical lip balm brand supported by transparent ingredient choices and honest marketing. Through this process, they act as informed advocates who challenge greenwashing and promote responsible consumer behaviour within the school community.

Students may offer non-commercial sample products or awareness kits for school or community use, or donate them—where appropriate and safe—to local women's shelters, accompanied by informational materials on natural skincare and sustainability. This reinforces empathy, care, and ethical responsibility while respecting health, safety, and consent considerations.

Students host a product awareness day or exhibition to showcase their design journey, ethical research, and final products. This platform allows them to educate peers and families, engage in dialogue about sustainability in everyday products, and reflect on how design choices can contribute to positive social and environmental impact.

Assessment

MYP Assessment Criteria

N/A ☑ A: Inquiring and analysing

N/A ☑ B: Developing ideas

N/A ☑ C: Creating the solution

N/A ☑ D: Evaluating

Description

Learning Experiences

Prior Learning Experiences

Students bring prior experience using the MYP Design Cycle, analysing products, applying sustainability concepts, and creating simple prototypes. Prior learning is assessed through diagnostic discussions, entry tasks, product analysis, and review of previous portfolios to identify understanding, misconceptions, and readiness for ethical cosmetic design.

Learning Experiences and Teaching Strategies

Students begin the unit by connecting the design challenge to their own experiences through guided discussions and reflection tasks focused on personal lip care needs and frustrations with existing products. They explore why lip balm is used, identify problems in commercial products, and build awareness of sustainability and ethical concerns within the cosmetic industry.

Students then engage in structured research to understand natural ingredients, their functions, and their impact on safety, texture, shelf life, and the environment. This includes analysing information texts, researching existing lip balm products, deconstructing sustainability claims, and examining ethical issues such as packaging waste and ingredient sourcing. Findings are organized using mind maps, research tables, and product analysis tools.

Based on their research, students define a clear design problem and target user, and summarize their intentions in a design brief. They establish success criteria that consider functionality, user needs, sustainability, and practical constraints. Students generate multiple design ideas, explore branding and aesthetic choices, and refine their thinking through peer feedback before selecting and justifying a final design.

Students then plan the making process by selecting ingredients, developing a recipe, creating diagrams, and preparing a step-by-step production plan that includes safety and hygiene considerations. They proceed to create the lip balm prototype through guided practical sessions, documenting changes, challenges, and decisions throughout the process.

Following production, students design and conduct simple testing methods to evaluate their product against the success criteria. They analyse results, reflect on user experience and environmental impact, and identify areas for improvement. The unit culminates in students communicating their design journey and sustainability message through a promotional pitch or green screen advertisement, supported by reflective evaluation of both product and process.

Student Expectations

At the start of the unit, students are introduced to the design challenge, learning goals, and final outcomes through a structured unit launch discussion. The purpose of the unit, success criteria, and connection to sustainability and ethical design are made

explicit using age-appropriate language and real-world examples.

Expectations are clarified through **scaffolded task sheets, templates, and exemplars** provided at each stage of the learning process, including research organizers, problem statement scaffolds, design brief templates, planning diagrams, and evaluation checklists. These tools clearly indicate what students must do, how work should be structured, and what quality looks like.

Assessment criteria are unpacked progressively using student-friendly explanations and checklists rather than being presented all at once. Teachers model expectations through think-alouds, demonstrations, anchor charts, and sample responses, particularly for research, planning, making, and evaluation tasks.

Ongoing feedback is provided through peer review, conferencing, and formative reflections, helping students understand how well they are meeting expectations and what needs improvement. Reflection prompts and self-assessment opportunities further support students in monitoring their own progress and responsibilities throughout the unit.

Feedback

Feedback in this unit is ongoing, timely, and focused on improvement rather than judgement. It is embedded at each stage of the design process to help students refine their thinking, make informed decisions, and develop confidence as designers.

During inquiry and research phases, feedback is provided through teacher questioning, annotated comments on research organizers, and guided discussions. This helps students clarify misconceptions, strengthen research quality, and deepen understanding of sustainability and ethical issues. Peer feedback is structured using prompts and checklists so students learn how to give and receive specific, actionable suggestions.

As students develop ideas and plans, feedback is used to support decision-making and justification. Teacher conferencing and peer review activities guide students to evaluate feasibility, alignment with success criteria, and ethical considerations. This ensures students revise their work before moving into production, reinforcing the idea that feedback informs next steps rather than concluding learning.

During the creation phase, verbal feedback and observation-based guidance help students refine technical skills, adjust processes safely, and document changes meaningfully. Students use reflection logs to respond to feedback and explain how it influenced modifications to their design or plan.

In the evaluation and communication stages, feedback supports critical reflection. Students compare outcomes against criteria, respond to peer and teacher comments, and identify realistic improvements. This cycle reinforces reflective practice and helps students view feedback as an essential tool for growth, problem-solving, and responsible design.

Differentiation

Differentiation of Content

Learning materials are differentiated to support varied readiness levels and language profiles. Students access information through multiple formats, including simplified reading packs, visual diagrams, videos, ingredient charts, and teacher-guided explanations. Key vocabulary related to cosmetic science, sustainability, and design is explicitly taught using glossaries and visual anchors. Extension resources are provided for students who require greater challenge, such as deeper ethical case studies or advanced ingredient analysis.

Differentiation of Process

Students engage with learning through varied pathways and levels of scaffolding. Structured templates, sentence starters, checklists, and guided questions support learners who need clarity and organization, while more open-ended inquiry tasks allow independent learners to extend their thinking. Flexible grouping is used strategically—individual work, pairs, and collaborative groups—based on task purpose and student need. Teacher conferencing, peer feedback, and verbal check-ins provide responsive support and allow adjustments during the learning process.

Differentiation of Product

Students are given choice in how they demonstrate learning and understanding. While core outcomes remain consistent, students may vary aspects such as formulation complexity, branding depth, packaging design, or communication format. Products may include written reflections, visual diagrams, prototypes, advertisements, or oral explanations. Clear success criteria ensure equity, while choice allows students to leverage their strengths in communication, creativity, or technical skills.

Reflections

General Reflections

Prior to studying the unit



Ishita Bhattacharjee Jan 27, 2026 at 12:14 PM

This unit is likely to engage students because it connects directly to their daily lives, personal care routines, and consumer choices, making learning immediately relevant and tangible. Students are naturally curious about cosmetic products, branding, and sustainability claims, which creates high intrinsic motivation. They already bring prior knowledge of basic product analysis, user needs, sustainability concepts, and the design cycle, as well as practical experience with simple materials, research tasks, and reflective evaluation from previous Design units.

Students have previously encountered this discipline through product-based design challenges, analysis of existing products, and introductory discussions on ethical consumption and environmental impact. Experience suggests that students will show strong engagement during hands-on experimentation and creative branding tasks, while requiring structured scaffolding for research depth, justification, and evaluation. Collaborative tasks and visual, media-based learning typically elicit high participation, especially when students are given choice and clear success criteria.

The unit offers strong opportunities to develop IB Learner Profile attributes such as **Caring** (through ethical sourcing and sustainability), **Reflective** (through evaluation and iteration), **Open-minded** (by considering diverse consumer needs and global perspectives), and **Communicators** (through pitches, advertisements, and peer feedback). Interdisciplinary connections naturally emerge with Science (material properties, mixtures), Individuals and Societies (global supply chains, labour ethics, consumption), Language and Literature (persuasive language and media analysis), and Arts (visual identity and branding).

Students tend to prefer collaborative, discussion-based learning with opportunities for creative expression, visual communication, and real-world relevance. The unit intentionally builds on these preferences through group research, peer review, media creation, and hands-on making. Meaningful service learning opportunities are embedded through ethical product design, awareness-building around sustainable cosmetics, and community education initiatives. The unit also lends itself to personal or community projects, such as awareness campaigns, eco-friendly product exhibitions, or partnerships with local organisations promoting sustainability.

Students' multilingualism is used as a learning resource by encouraging translanguaging during brainstorming, research, and peer discussion. Learners may access sources in multiple languages, compare sustainability practices across cultures, and draw on linguistic diversity to deepen understanding of global markets and ethical perspectives. This approach values students' linguistic identities while strengthening conceptual understanding and international-mindedness.

During the unit

Krishnamoorthy S May 4, 2026 at 9:25 AM

During the unit, student engagement has remained high because the content directly mirrors their **daily routines** and consumer habits. The hands-on nature of the cosmetic branding tasks has successfully tapped into their intrinsic motivation, though, as anticipated, some students require more **structured scaffolding** to move beyond surface-level research into deeper justification and evaluation.
The **collaborative nature** of the tasks has fostered productive discussions, particularly during the experimentation phase. We are seeing strong evidence of the **IB Learner Profile** in action; students are showing genuine **Caring** as they grapple with the ethics of supply chains and **Open-mindedness** when considering diverse global consumer needs.
The use of **multilingualism** as a resource has been particularly effective. By allowing students to research sustainability practices in their home languages, they have brought a much broader, international perspective to our class discussions.
Moving forward, the focus will be on maintaining this momentum by providing clear **success criteria** as they transition from the creative "making" phase to the final reflective evaluation



Ishita Bhattacharjee May 4, 2026 at 9:26 AM

Criteria A was effectively achieved due to strong scaffolding. The use of the **question matrix**, guided texts, and explicit practice of **skimming and scanning strategies** supported students in generating relevant research and identifying key information.

Canva-based templates helped students stay focused, organise their ideas clearly, and maintain structure in their responses. As a result, most students were able to meet the expectations of inquiring and analysing with clarity and relevance.

Students were confident in gathering information; however, some still required support in **justifying their findings** rather than only presenting them.

After the unit

Krishnamoorthy S May 4, 2026 at 9:33 AM

Learning Outcomes & Evidence
The primary learning outcomes were a deep understanding of the **design cycle**, the ethics of **global supply chains**, and the ability to synthesize **material science** with **brand identity**. Evidence of learning is clearly seen in the students' final product prototypes and their ability to justify material choices based on sustainability.

ATL Reflection
ATL Strands Developed:
- **Research (Information Literacy):** Finding and verifying the sustainability claims of raw materials.
- **Communication:** Using appropriate forms of writing and media for specific audiences (consumers vs. stakeholders).
- **Social (Collaboration):** Working in teams to delegate tasks and provide peer feedback.

What Worked Well:
The **"Peer Critique Gallery Walk"** worked exceptionally well for the *Reflection* strand. Students were able to give and receive constructive feedback, which directly improved their final iterations.

What Could Be Improved:
The **Self-Management (Organization)** element was a struggle for some teams. In the future, I would implement **digital**

Kanban boards or weekly "stand-up meetings" to help students track their project milestones more effectively.



Ishita Bhattacharjee May 5, 2026 at 11:52 AM

We need to plan more effective scaffolding strategies during Criterion D to better support students through the design and evaluation process. Additionally, providing exposure to more authentic evaluation environments will help students apply their learning in real-world contexts, strengthening their analytical thinking, reflection, and ability to assess the effectiveness of their solutions beyond classroom conditions.